

Title

Conjoint Couple-Based Counseling Improves Family Planning Uptake: A Cluster Randomized Trial

Abstract

Engagement with both spouses during family planning consultations may enhance contraceptive adoption and couple communication. We randomized 1201 married couples to either receive enhanced counseling delivered to both partners, emphasizing gender equity and joint decision-making (intervention), or standard family planning counseling (control). At 9-month follow-up, participants in the intervention group demonstrated higher uptake of modern contraceptive methods compared with controls. Qualitative assessment of the clinical encounter quality, measured through validated instruments, showed that couples receiving the structured gender-aware approach reported greater satisfaction with communication and support. Mediation analysis suggested that improved perceived quality of the healthcare interaction partially explained the intervention's effect on contraceptive adoption. These findings support the integration of couple-centered and gender-equitable communication strategies into family planning programs to promote contraceptive use while respecting reproductive autonomy.